

Chapter 7

Stories and Testimonies

Since its inception, Bitcoin has served and continues to serve many uses in cases where current systems have failed, for people most disenfranchised or excluded by current monetary and banking systems of the world, or when such systems have been weaponised against individuals or nations. As of 2021, around 1.4 billion people across the globe (roughly 1 in 5 of the global population) remain unbanked and lack access to financial services. (0)

The right and access to personal sovereign banking of one's funds is only one of many value propositions Bitcoin offers. Over the years, Bitcoin's use cases have tangibly helped the lives of many. The following are only a few of the stories and testimonies of how Bitcoin has served as a life raft, economically empowering individuals, groups, and communities around the globe in the face of monetary crises, economic repression, persecution, and tyranny.

In each of their stories, we will see how Bitcoin, contrary to fiat money (and the mark of the beast to a much greater extent), seeks to impose itself on no one. Moreover, as it has grown and monetized, it continues to distinguish itself as a peaceful, neutral, and uncensorable monetary technology. It is never forced on others, but is always just there, available to anyone, anytime, anywhere to use as a liquid store of value beyond the reach of government control and censorship.

Kal – Bitcoin in Ethiopia

This interview features a young Bitcoiner in Ethiopia and offers a firsthand look at personal experiences with Bitcoin in Ethiopia. Demonstrating how a neutral, permissionless monetary technology intersects with everyday life in challenging economic and political environments. (8)

For Kal Kassa in Ethiopia, Bitcoin is about bridging the gap between the upper and lower classes in a corrupt system. "Wages do grow, but not on par with inflation. Salaries in urban areas have perhaps double over the past decade, but goods have gone up by 3 to 5 times. The upper classes use the dollar as their unit of account, but the poor outside the city, well, dollars are official illegal for them."

Kal's brother was arrest for simply have a \$20 bill in his pocket, but the arrest wasn't enough to stop Kal. "I created a Telegram group where I pay freelancers, graphic designers, and translators based in Ethiopic, with bitcoins." In America, most people treat Bitcoin as an investment, or as a savings account, but here, I use it as a medium of exchange. It's a part of my life.

– Kal Kassa, Human Rights Foundation

Fadey - A Young Refugee

During the Russo-Ukrainian war, displaced persons and refugees fled from the conflict with their savings in Bitcoin, carrying their hardware wallets or committing their Bitcoin seed phrase to memory (1).

Fadey also took a USB stick with him across the border containing 40% of his life savings, or about \$2,000 sats in bitcoin. That thumb drive, combined with a unique passcode, became the key to his financial survival. “I could just write my seed phrase on a piece of paper and take it with me,” explained Fadey. His experience highlights some of the most important characteristics of bitcoin: It’s valid across borders, requires no bank, and is tethered to its owner by a password, making it a lot harder to steal than cash.

– CNBC, story of Fadey, a young Ukrainian refugee

Carlos - Borderless Money

Helping individuals and families in Venezuela to survive a collapsing national currency, and empowering Venezuelans to flee economic repression without having their money seized by the authorities (2).

Venezuelan military personnel have a reputation for seizing the money of people who want to leave, but Juan’s being in Bitcoin, was accessible only with a password he had memorised, writes Hernández and adds: ‘Borderless money’ is more than a buzzword for those of us who live in a collapsing economy and a collapsing dictatorship.

– Carlos Hernández, Venezuelan economist

Win – Political Exile and Economic Exit

Enabling Burmese refugees to bypass state-frozen bank accounts and transport their wealth across borders without physical assets or government permission. For those like Win Ko Ko Aung, Bitcoin provided a critical financial lifeline, allowing them to reclaim their autonomy even while exiled by an authoritarian regime (3).

I was a social entrepreneur, a public figure, and the author of one of Burma’s best-selling books in 2020 titled “A 21st Century Burmese Guy.” I used my voice and platform to speak out against the military coup and mobilize peaceful resistance — and paid the price. My bank accounts were frozen, and I was charged with Section 505(A) of the Penal Code — a law criminalizing free speech, which put my life at risk. I fled without even having time to grab my passport and crossed the Burmese border into Thailand, hiding among migrant labourers to avoid being captured.

I made it to the US with almost nothing — except a small amount of Bitcoin I had once bought out of curiosity. With my money trapped back home, Bitcoin helped me survive. That

experience became the foundation of my work at Human Rights Foundation, where I now help others learn to use Bitcoin as a tool for financial freedom. All while being in exile.

In contrast to state-controlled [digital] money like CBDCs, Bitcoin offers something unique: unstoppable, uncensorable, permissionless money. It operates outside the reach of both authoritarian regimes and central banks. For people living under dictatorship, it's a tool for financial autonomy and freedom.

– Win Ko Ko Aung, Burmese author and human rights activist

Fereshteh – An Economic Lifeline

In Afghanistan, serving as an essential payment channel that bypasses economic sanctions design to cripple the economic life of Afghans and restrictive local bank withdrawal limits amid a food security crisis. By utilising digital currency, vulnerable individuals, particularly Afghan women, were able to receive emergency funds and carried their wealth with them even if displaced (4).

The value of the currency tanking combined with the price of household essentials rocketing has led to widespread food insecurity, Insider reported. With foreign aid suspended, an overwhelming majority (98%) of Afghans don't have enough to eat, according to the World Food Programme.

The situation is particularly "horrific" for the nation's women, Forough said, many of whom have been forced out of jobs and into poverty. On top of being desperately hungry, she explained that many of her female students have struggled to pay for medicine and internet access.

Forough said she wanted to send emergency payments to these women, but, frustratingly, most of her transactions were blocked by Western Union and JPMorganChase. Once some of the money did eventually go through, often, her students were unable to withdraw cash at local banks.

Forough said that donating cryptocurrencies holds many advantages for the women in Afghanistan, including a reduced risk in the money being confiscated.

"And if they got displaced from Afghanistan or any part of Afghanistan, they can also carry their finances with themselves everywhere they go," she continued. "That, to me, is empowering."

– Business Insider, Fereshteh Forough, founder of Code to Inspire in Herat, Afghanistan

Tony - Sovereignty Over Savings

The exit and life raft to economic survival amidst a concurrent economic, monetary, and banking crisis in Lebanon, where banks severely restricted access to savings amid the currency collapse of the Lebanese pound.

In 2019, Lebanon's banks began restricting access to savings, imposing informal capital controls without any legal framework. "Overnight, people lost access to their funds," Tony says. "You couldn't withdraw your own money, and even if you could, it was in Lebanese pounds that were rapidly losing value."

In early 2020, Lebanon defaulted on its foreign debt, and the value of the Lebanese pound plummeted. Hyperinflation set in, destroying the purchasing power of ordinary people. Tony watched helplessly as his savings evaporated and his businesses crumbled. "I went from being a successful entrepreneur to having just \$70 to my name in what felt like the blink of an eye," he recalls. "I couldn't pay rent, school fees, or even afford basic groceries... If I had known about Bitcoin before the crisis, it could have saved me, Bitcoin would have given me a way to store value outside the banking system, which completely failed. I wouldn't have been locked out of my own savings, and I could have preserved my wealth as the Lebanese pound collapsed... Bitcoin isn't tied to any government or central bank, so it can't be manipulated the way the Lebanese pound was, it's a hedge against hyperinflation, which would have been critical when prices were doubling and tripling every few months."

Tony's experience is a stark reminder of the fragility of fiat systems and the importance of financial sovereignty. "With bitcoin in your custody, you have the power to protect yourself from corruption, manipulation, and inflation," Tony says. "You don't need permission from a bank or a government to manage your own money. And that's exactly what makes Bitcoin the ultimate tool for financial freedom."

– Bitcoin Magazine, Tony Yazbeck, entrepreneur & Bitcoin educator

Dichter – Freezing the Freedom Convoy

Moreover, even in well-established democracies, monetary and banking systems still nonetheless remain powerful tools that can be weaponised against the citizenry to enforce the government's interest. When the Canadian government invoked the Emergencies Act to directly freeze bank accounts of protesters of the Freedom Convoy and pressure crowdfunding platforms like GoFundMe, organisers turned to Bitcoin as a lifeline for truckers and their families. (5)

And through it all, the Freedom Convoy quickly became one of the most high-profile test cases for the use of Bitcoin as a permissionless and censorship-resistant way of transacting value to whomever, wherever, whenever.

"This will be a historical moment for Bitcoin," explained B.J. Dichter, a Toronto resident born and raised in Canada, who was a long-haul trucker himself before becoming a spokesperson for the Freedom Convoy. "Because we always talked about this hypothetical, the government tyranny of blocking your bank accounts, stealing your money and whatever... Well, now they just did. So, it proved everything. Everything that people said about Bitcoin like, 'Oh, that's hyperbolic. That's never gonna happen.' Well, guess what? Yesterday's conspiracy is today's reality. And I think in the future, people are going to see, that was the moment that regular

people and everybody understood that the government can't track it, can't block it, and shouldn't be able to."

On February 3, a committee from the Canadian House of Commons asked GoFundMe officials to testify over security concerns about where the donated funds were coming from and where they might be going. Members of Parliament also asked the Financial Transactions and Reports Analysis Centre of Canada (FINTRAC) to testify. The next day, GoFundMe removed the campaign.

Several other centralised fundraising platforms started collecting funds for the Freedom Convoy, but it was clear that the Canadian government had drawn a line in the sand. Fundraisers on Christian-focused donations platform GiveSendGo had collected more than \$8.5 million for the protestors, but the Ontario Superior Court of Justice granted a court order to freeze the funds. By late February, Canada had invoked the Emergencies Act and had frozen more than 75 bank accounts linked to the protests.

"Three years ago, if you had asked me what's the chance that Canada would freeze individuals' bank accounts... I'd find it really hard to believe it was 20%," said Greg Foss, an outspoken Bitcoin advocate and fifth-generation Canadian. "And three years later, it's 100%... It was not a good thing for [the country's] freedom."

The saga served as one of the most high-profile test cases for Bitcoin as a sovereign financial rail in its thirteen-year history. As Bitcoiners continue to tout the technology as an off-ramp from undue censorship and surveillance, its use as a system for getting hundreds of thousands of dollars in value directly into the hands of those who had been blacklisted by the Canadian government may be the most potent illustration of that power to date. Perhaps most significantly of all, it demonstrated on the world stage that fiat can only be used how governments decide.

– Bitcoin Magazine, How Bitcoin Fuelled the Freedom Convoy and Defied Government Crackdown

Yeonmi – From Silence to Sovereign

Last but not least, the author would like to share the powerful testimony of Yeonmi Park in her conversation with humanitarian worker Alex Gladstein at the 2022 Miami Bitcoin Conference. Having escaped North Korea, she survived to tell the tales of the Hermit Kingdom's use of economic repression to enforce state loyalty, and the exploitation of defectors in China left vulnerable by financial disenfranchisement. In contrast to this darkness, she explains how Bitcoin is empowering North Korean women and their children through church communities. Ultimately, her description of the state's total control over money stands as a microcosm of the tyranny of that of the Antichrist's to come.

Yeonmi Park: I'm so grateful talk about Bitcoin and also freedom... I remember when I was young the government was telling people that you should deposit money in the bank and then people did because we trusted our dear leader, I mean he was our god to us. Once we put our money in the bank account it was locked nobody could get the money out of the bank accounts, only people who had the connection to the bankers and the government officials who could get the money out and so this is a real struggle right in North Korea. Private Property is banned you cannot own a car, you cannot own a house, you cannot own anything, so therefore if you make a [transaction of] money in the black market system, you have to hide somewhere in the house.

One time actually I remember my mother's best friend, there's many thieves in North Korea, she was hiding the cash, the hard earned the cash inside of where she was cooking food, and the husband came without knowing and burned the whole thing, so her life savings [just] gone like that. In North Korea because we don't know how to hide the cash, I still remember my mother would take the stockings out and put the cash and wrapping around her body to hide the money because that was the only way we could carry cash.

By 2009, we all know that North Korea strived to become a socialist paradise where there's no inequality, so the regime decided how are we going to make everybody "equal", is they designed in 2009 we are going to do something called the "currency exchange", which means previous money that you had will worth nothing, literally [became worthless].

Alex Gladstein: That people had been saving for decades...

YP: Yes, in a black market for like 70 years people working the black markets and saving this money, and the regime wanted to make sure that everybody is "equal" and take all the power from North Korean people so they did something called the "currency exchange", and they said each family now they give them only one week seven days...

AG: One week, you had one week to turn in your old money?

YP: Yes, and they said and for the people in Pyongyang, the people [in the countryside] only three days. Each family can only get new cash that was worth of buying two kilograms of rice. So regardless how much [old North Korean won] you have, your money meant nothing the next day. After that "currency exchange", the people now actually do not have any money and they are actually trying to find a way to get alternative moneys.

AG: So the regime found a very cruel way to try to make everyone equal... What you just described in 2009 was is known as demonetisation. So cash can help people and it does help people around the world, a lot of people save around the world especially in dollars under their mattress or somewhere in their house but there's a there's a very cruel way that the government can even take that from you, and that's again called demonetisation: where they say "oh all that money that's no longer worth anything anymore". And as you're just telling us they only gave people a week or even a few days depending on which caste system you were in North Korea... Basically you only have a certain amount of time to turn that in and then in

exchange you'll get this new money but you can only get a certain amount. So I mean we don't often hear about finance and economics and money in in the human rights discussions, you know I worked on North Korea issues for years and years and years and never heard about this or learned about this until I started asking questions about Bitcoin and money. And in that vein, when you were growing up, did they teach you about money in school?

YP: No, the word in North Korea "profit" is banned, I mean they think money as evil and any business enterprise private business is evil so they don't teach us anything about economy and money. So basically what people, what we have to do is relying on the government who is going to give us public rations, but they didn't do that, so our only choice was dying from starvation, and that's [why] I escaped from North Korea when I was 13 years old.

AG: Can you talk a little bit about the role that money played in in your escape at all? And maybe how it was a limiting factor or how you wish you had a different kind of money? Take us through that a little bit.

YP: Yeah I think it's so surreal for me coming from North Korea actually sitting in Miami, this very liberal place right now it is full of electricity... But when I escaped from North Korea at 13, I arrived in China, and they sold me for less than 300 dollars as a sex slave, and there are right now 300,000 North Korean women in China [that] are being sold. The reason why we are being sold is because we [are debanked and] cannot have bank accounts. And when North Korean women get captured and sent back, if they somehow able to hide 50 dollars they don't have to die in the prison camp, but the regime is so vicious, they even check everybody part [of your body]. You cannot even imagine, and they even check after you go to bathroom so there's no way you can hide anything or jewelry or money in your body. But something like Bitcoin, if you remember your [seed phrase] you go out, you talk to a broker, they give you the money and you can come out. But because North Koreans has no [and doesn't know a] medium like that, they've been suffering and dying from this tragedy.

AG: I think what Yeonmi has been describing is kind of the end game of fiat money is a totally centrally planned money system that the rulers can arbitrarily change at any time, and that's what the North Korean people have had to endure. So Yeonmi, you told me something very interesting about how some people in China are using Bitcoin to help aid North Koreans who are stuck there... again let's remember people like Yeonmi who escaped into China don't necessarily speak Chinese, they've never been to these places before, and 70% of the people who escape are women and they're trafficked or interned in some way. They have no bank account they have no access to any sort of [fiat] money system. So Yeonmi can you walk us through how you've heard that Bitcoin is kind of penetrating through this system?

YP: Yeah I mean actually I'm sure not a lot of us haven't seen a North Korean before right? Because right now there are only 209 North Korean defectors [who have] made it to America during the last 80 years. So most of North Koreans when they escape they do not end up like me in America...

AG: Or even in South Korea most don't make it most get stuck in China or die...

YP: Right so they end up in China and [the Chinese government] they do not want to help these people. And not only that China had one child policy, because of that they have 30 million men [who] cannot find [a spouse], especially in Northeastern China which borders North Korea... So they buy North Korean girls like me as their sex slaves. And when these women go to and meet their supposedly Chinese husbands, they have a child. If the women get captured and send back North Korea, mothers [will be] sent to prison camps and die, and child... The problem is [the child] cannot get a state ID, the Chinese government does not accept the child as a Chinese so they become stateless children. And these children without ID [in Chinese called Hukou] they cannot even go to elementary school. So there are three hundred thousand North Korean women right now in China and the children are about up to like a million of them, we don't know quite fully how many are there. So now there are underground church groups starting a kind of homeschooling, sending bitcoins to a Chinese broker and they buy school supplies to children who cannot go to elementary school, so they don't [also] end up being trafficked and going to brothels and become a prostitute, so they can get educated and find a way out. And there's a way that we can empower these women and children through Bitcoin.

AG: I had mentioned to you earlier today that when I first met you seven or eight years ago uh how crazy is it that one day we'd be speaking together at a Bitcoin conference. You didn't know what Bitcoin was at the time and now you've been studying it you know a lot about it, what do you think if you could go back to North Korea and start telling people that there's this currency that's digital that governments don't control? I mean once that starts to pick up traction inside North Korea what do you think will happen?

YP: I think that's the thing, when this morning we had talked about how the fiat currency, under fiat currency 169 million people died right? Like in my life nothing has been more evil than [my] government has been. I think the North Korean regime is almost testament how evil a government can be to individuals, so I think if the North Korean people know there's a way that they can have their own autonomy to decide what money they can use, I think you we will see a different word that we cannot even possibly fathom right now because we've been always under this government's control and we imagine that individuals have that power in our hands we can create a much better world [in which] nobody needs to be sold [or enslaved].

– Yeonmi Park & Alex Gladstein, Bitcoin Conference 2022

Foreshadows of the Beast

Yeonmi, Tony, Dichter, Fereshteh, Win, Carlos, and Fadey's stories are just a few voices among the millions across the globe who have faced, and are facing, financial and economic repression and disenfranchisement. Though they are from different parts of the world, across distinct cultures, ethnicities, languages, and continents, their stories unite around one notion that loudly echoes the economic reality of the mark of the beast: the weaponisation of money to serve the interests of the state.

And he causes all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead, and that no one may be able to buy or sell except him who has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of his name.

– Revelation 13:16-17

Each of their account offers a glimpse into the future of the world under the Antichrist's control and tyranny. Similar to Fereshteh's account, there will be famine and starvation in the end times (Matt. 24:7; Luke 21:11). Similar to Fadey's account, there will be conflict and wars (Matt. 24:7; Dan. 7:21; Rev. 13:7). Similar to Win's account, there will be fleeing and exodus of people from organised persecutions by the beastly government (cf. Mark. 13:14; Rev. 12:6; 20:4). Similar to all their accounts, we would certainly expect the confiscation and freezing of money in the savings and bank accounts of all who do not comply to the Antichrist's government and receive the mark of the beast. The weaponisation of fiat monetary systems and rails against all (Rev. 13:16) to enforce absolute loyalty and control of the citizenry to the government and the Antichrist.

One should not feel contempt just because they are privileged to live in a developed nation and have never personally experienced a fiat currency collapse or disenfranchisement from the monetary and banking system. We know that when the Antichrist comes and takes power over the world, all will be economically disenfranchised regardless of one's age, economic status, social status, race, and nationality (Rev. 13:7, 16-17). As the centrepiece of the Antichrist's schemes, the mark will serve a most incisive purpose of immediately revealing to all (most importantly to the Antichrist) those who are loyal, and those who are not to the Antichrist. Forcing a very immediate and fateful decision to receive the mark as the display of one's submission and loyalty to the Antichrist, to face social and economic persecution, and even death (cf. Rev. 20:4). Thereby deceiving many into receiving the mark of the beast (Rev. 19:20) with the pretence of granted economic survival, yet unaware of the eternal consequences of this action (Rev. 14:9-11).

We began the book by identifying and analysing the problem, methodically arriving at a solution, and now seeing the efficacy and real-world trials of Bitcoin against the problem(s) it was created by its creator to solve. Whether if you are a Christian know that this problem will be very real in the foreseeable future as the Antichrist and the mark of the beast must come before the coming of the true Christ, but do not know how rest of the billions and billions of people would make it through those fateful three and a half years without the ability to buy or sell. Or, you are a seasoned Bitcoin veteran who has survived multiple cycles and runs their own lightning node, you know that Bitcoin is **the** uncensorable, unstoppable freedom money, but have not fully grasped the true scale of the problem that Bitcoin proposes to solve until picking up this book.

Masters never don't do the basics, nor can one achieve the level of mastery by skipping over them. Respecting and making known the tried-and-true methods and know-how that got us where

we are as Bitcoiners will probably help many others learn how to use Bitcoin. Without further ado, let us continue to the final, but perhaps the most important chapter of this book: the basics of using Bitcoin.